transform their mucky new home into a divinely chosen land.

Their god Huitzilopochtli, they declared, had told them long before that they would know they had reached the end of the wanderings when they saw a sign, an eagle sitting on a cactus (*tenochtli*) with a snake held in its beak: "It is there that we shall fix ourselves, it is there that we shall rule, that we shall wait, that we shall meet the various nations and that with our arrow and our shield we shall overthrow them." When they arrived at Lake Texcoco, the story went on, they sloshed their way into the middle of it and suddenly saw the eagle of prophecy, "poised on a cactus, eating with delight. . . . And they wept, crying, 'At last we have been worthy of our god; we have deserved the reward; with astonishment we have seen the sign: our city shall be here.'" It was a wonderful story, and useful; it allowed them to celebrate the inevitable.[6]

The Mexica began to build houses for themselves on one of the larger islands, where underlying rock would keep them from sinking down into the bog that surrounded them. This island they named Tenochtitlán, after the cactus in the prophecy. They lived on fish and waterfowl; they trapped and hunted and traded the meat with the surrounding cities for bricks and timber and the other necessities of life. Slowly, Tenochtitlán was transformed from a muddy survivor's camp into a town. Slowly, the tribe of the Mexica was becoming a nation: the Aztecs. But they did not forget the horror of those first years on the island. "This is the place of the serpent's anger," the Aztec priests chanted, over a century later, as they descended into Lake Texcoco for their ritual yearly bath, "the humming of the water-mosquito, the flight of the wild-duck, the murmur of the white rushes."[7]

Sometime between 1337 and 1357, a splinter group of Aztecs moved out of Tenochtitlán, to a dry patch of land less than a mile away, at the north end of the lake. The Dominican friar Diego Durán, who gathered and preserved the oral histories of the Aztecs in the sixteenth century, tells us that Tenochtitlán had grown large enough to be divided into four sections, or *barrios*, with each section parceled out to the men of the city. "Some of the elders who felt they deserved more property than they had received . . . rebelled," Durán writes. "They decided to seek a different place, and by going through the reeds and rushes they found a small dry piece of land." Here, four chieftains ("restless and seditious men, of evil intentions") built a second city and called it Tlatelolco. The twin cities on Lake Texcoco existed in a state of constant simmering hostility: "They were never at peace," Durán says, "nor did they get on well with their brothers."[8]

The division forced both Aztec settlements to shore up their defenses. "[The men of Tlatelolco] have abandoned us, they have gone away," one of the elders of Tenochtitlán explained. "I am afraid that with their cunning they